These early political ideas, including the Mandate of Heaven, became more elaborate and codified in the subsequent Zhou dynasty (1046–256 BCE), which succeeded the Shang dynasty at virtually the precise coming together of the heavenly constellations again in 1046 BCE . But this was a violent and bloody change of guard, and this pattern of violent political transitions would recur again and again in the future. But the Zhou rulers soon began to cloak themselves in the mantle of benevolent rule and set out to put in place a whole set of written codes and norms that would endure as the basic political character of the Chinese polity through the ages. The Zhou rewrote the history of their violent overthrow of the Shang and began the tradition of dynastic history-writing. This occurred with every dynastic change. There was always the fear of the power of the past to discredit the future. This has continued to be the case into modern times in China. For example, the Tiananmen incident of 1989, where peaceful protests were violently and brutally suppressed, has been demonized as ‘a counter-revolutionary riot’.

Although the Zhou ruled over a multi-state kingdom with a number of vassals acknowledging Zhou overlordship, we already encounter the idea of a powerful ruler being indispensable to maintaining peace and order in the realm. The Zhou dynasty began to decline around the sixth century BCE with the vassal states emerging as the Warring States, and it eventually came to an end with China’s first truly centralized empire of the Qin in 232 BCE .

During the Warring States period, the political ideas of the Zhou were elaborated by philosophers like Confucius (551–479 BCE), who further refined the concept of a powerful ruler who would unite ‘All Under Heaven’ and ensure peace and order through the strict observance of political and social norms. These norms regulated the relations between ruler and subject, between different social categories, and between members of the family. Society was conceived of as a hierarchical system, as was the family, and it was through the maintenance of this hierarchy that harmony could be ensured. The community and the collective had to be given priority over individual interests. The Confucian ideal was of a sage king presiding over a polity and society where everyone knew his place, and